

FROM CONFLICT TO CONSTRUCTION

Human Agency, Material Friction, and the Engineering of a Post-Scarcity World

A functionalist critique of dialectical materialism and a constructive theory of progress

Core Thesis

Material conditions matter profoundly, but they are better understood as the environment in which human purposes encounter resistance than as the ultimate source of those purposes. Human beings act, improvise, cooperate, and build in response to friction. Over long timescales, successful solutions compound into new material and psychological baselines. The practical task is therefore not to perfect conflict, but to diagnose friction and construct systems that make destructive arrangements obsolete.

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Abstract

This essay begins from a sympathetic reading of dialectical and historical materialism. Marxist thought remains unusually powerful as a diagnostic language for structural constraints, class interests, alienation, institutional inertia, and the way material arrangements shape the range of practical choices available to human beings. The disagreement developed here is not that material conditions are irrelevant. It is about explanatory and practical primacy. The proposed alternative treats human beings as agents with phenomenologically real, often deeply rooted orientations toward purposes such as care, mastery, duty, belonging, protection, creation, or meaning. Historical context supplies the vocabulary, tools, constraints, and implementation details through which those orientations become concrete.

On this view, history can be modeled as a recurring engineering loop: desire encounters material or institutional friction; people act to reduce that friction; successful solutions become new infrastructure, knowledge, norms, and capabilities; those new conditions create a higher baseline from which further problems can be addressed. Conflict can reveal a fault, but it is not the only - or even the most productive - mechanism of change. The deeper engine is construction. The essay therefore argues for treating Marxism as a diagnostic instrument rather than a total theory of human development, and for orienting social progress around two mutually reinforcing forms of infrastructure: material post-scarcity and psychological post-scarcity. The desired future is not produced by destroying the old world first. It is built by creating systems so useful, humane, scalable, and low-friction that worse arrangements gradually lose their function.

1. Introduction: The Disagreement Is About Primacy

A productive critique of Marxism should begin by granting what is strongest in it. Human beings do not choose the century into which they are born, the technologies initially available to them, the legal order they inherit, the wealth of their parents, the language they first learn, or the institutions that structure their opportunities. These conditions are not cosmetic. They shape what can be attempted, how costly it is to attempt it, what risks are borne, and what kinds of action are intelligible at a given moment.

The disagreement begins when this true observation is made to carry more philosophical weight than it can bear. Material constraints explain the shape of a problem and the feasible space of solutions; they do not necessarily explain why a particular person experiences that state of affairs as a problem at all. Before a constraint becomes historically active, someone has to care about something it obstructs. A worker wants dignity or security. A parent wants a better life for a child. An inventor wants a machine to work. A reformer finds a practice intolerable. A merchant wants to move goods more reliably. A scientist wants to understand a failure. The material world pushes back, but the pushback becomes friction only relative to a purpose.

This essay develops a functionalist and partly teleological account of that relationship. It does not claim to prove the metaphysical origin of desire, nor that all people possess a single

universal purpose. It makes the more modest and practical claim that purposes are phenomenologically real, causally consequential, and often more stable than the particular language through which they are expressed. Context operationalizes desire; it need not create the whole of it. The key question is therefore not whether matter or mind exists first in an abstract metaphysical hierarchy. The more useful question is: what model best explains how people actually change the world, and which model produces better practical behavior when we try to build a better one?

2. Dialectical Materialism, Stated in Its Strongest Form

The phrase “dialectical materialism” is often used as shorthand for the philosophical method associated with Marx and Engels and later systematized within Marxist traditions. A historical nuance matters: Marx did not present a canonical textbook system under that label, and the familiar “three laws of dialectics” are especially associated with Engels and later Marxist formulations. Still, the broad family resemblance is clear: reality is material, historical, relational, dynamic, and marked by internal contradictions rather than static essences.

2.1 Materialism

Materialism gives explanatory priority to the concrete conditions of life: food, shelter, production, technology, labor, property relations, exchange, and the organization of social reproduction. In *The German Ideology*, Marx and Engels begin from the simple fact that people must be able to live before they can make history, and that satisfying existing needs generates new needs. This is one of the most durable insights in the tradition: consciousness never floats free of embodiment, resource constraints, or inherited institutions.

2.2 Dialectics

Dialectics rejects a picture of the world as a collection of fixed and independent objects. Systems develop through relationships, tensions, and transformations. In the classical Engelsian summary, dialectical development is described through the unity or interpenetration of opposites, the transformation of quantitative accumulation into qualitative change, and the negation of the negation. Whatever one thinks of these as universal “laws,” they function as useful prompts: look for internal tensions, thresholds, feedback, and the way a new order preserves some features of the old while reorganizing them.

2.3 Historical Materialism and Praxis

Applied to history, materialism emphasizes the interaction between productive forces - tools, knowledge, technology, energy, land, and productive capacity - and relations of production such as ownership, class, law, and institutional authority. When inherited relations become badly mismatched with productive possibilities, pressure for change grows. Yet Marx is not simply a philosopher of passivity. The *Theses on Feuerbach* explicitly criticizes a materialism that treats people as spectators rather than active participants, and insists that circumstances are changed by human beings. Likewise, *The Eighteenth Brumaire* states that people “make their own history,” although not under circumstances of their own choosing.

Important Qualification

The strongest version of Marxism already contains an agency-condition feedback loop. The critique in this essay is therefore not that Marx forgot action. It is that later deterministic readings - and some conflict-centered applications - can assign too much explanatory primacy to conditions and too little to the purposive activity that continuously reconstructs them.

3. Desire as Current; Context as Circuit

The central alternative can be expressed through a simple electrical analogy. Imagine a current that exists as potential but requires a circuit in order to do visible work. The circuit determines where the current can flow, how much resistance it encounters, what devices it can power, and what measurable effects it produces. Yet the fact that the circuit gives the current a path does not mean the circuit creates the current.

Human motivation can be understood similarly. A person may possess a stable orientation - toward making others happy, protecting a family, mastering a craft, fulfilling a duty, creating beauty, attaining status, discovering truth, or serving a community. The exact nouns and verbs through which this becomes actionable depend on history. A medieval person cannot want to found a software company in the literal sense; a modern person cannot become a guild master in the exact institutional world of the thirteenth century. But both may instantiate a deeper drive toward mastery, independence, service, achievement, or creation.

This model separates three layers that structural explanations often compress together:

- Core orientation: the relatively persistent motivational direction experienced by the person.
- Contextual expression: the symbols, occupations, institutions, identities, and narratives available for expressing that orientation.
- Operational problem: the concrete obstacle that prevents the person from moving toward the desired state here and now.

The philosophical advantage of this distinction is that it can accept almost everything a materialist says about context without reducing motivation to context. It also avoids claiming certainty about the ultimate origin of desire. Whether such orientations are biological, developmental, spiritual, archetypal, socially co-produced, or some mixture is an open question. Functionally, what matters is that people experience them as real enough to organize years of behavior around them.

4. A Constructive Model of History: Desire, Friction, Debugging, Compounding

Once purpose is treated as causally active, the historical mechanism looks less like matter producing consciousness in a one-directional chain and more like an iterative engineering

process. People seek ends. Reality resists. The resistance produces information. People modify their behavior, tools, institutions, knowledge, or environment. Successful modifications become part of the inherited world faced by the next person.

**PURPOSE -> FRICTION -> ACTION / EXPERIMENT -> KNOWLEDGE -> NEW
BASELINE -> NEW PURPOSES**

This loop is visible at every scale. A farmer changes irrigation because a crop fails. A machinist redesigns a fixture because setup time is excessive. A parent changes work patterns to create educational opportunity for a child. A legislature revises a rule after repeated injustice becomes legible. A city builds transit because congestion imposes intolerable costs. An entrepreneur notices a transaction that is slow, expensive, or humiliating and makes it easier. None of these actors is outside material reality; each is using agency inside reality to alter the next material state.

4.1 Friction Is Relative to a Goal

A condition becomes a problem only relative to an objective. A mountain is not an obstacle until someone wants to cross it. A wage is not “too low” except relative to needs, expectations, alternatives, and judgments about dignity. A bureaucratic procedure is not inefficient except relative to a desired throughput, fairness standard, or user experience. This does not make problems subjective in the sense of unreal. It means that problem-definition is a relationship between a world-state and an intended state.

4.2 “Profit” as a Selection Criterion

Competing philosophies can therefore be compared pragmatically. “Profit” here should be understood broadly as net functional surplus: more human capability, stability, flourishing, or productive output after accounting for material cost, coercion, cognitive load, conflict, and unintended consequences. A system aligned with the motives and practical needs of its participants should require less enforcement, generate less resistance, attract more voluntary participation, and create more surplus capacity for the next round of problem-solving. Over time, that advantage compounds.

This is not an argument that whatever wins is morally right. Brutal systems can persist for long periods, especially when they control violence or information. It is an argument about long-run adaptive pressure: arrangements that systematically waste human energy maintaining misalignment create openings for alternative institutions, technologies, norms, and businesses that deliver the same or better outcomes with less friction.

5. The Agency Problem: Everyone Is Already Acting

A recurring weakness in deterministic social theories appears when they describe ordinary people as products of circumstance while treating organizers, theorists, reformers, or revolutionaries as uniquely capable of seeing beyond those circumstances. Marx himself warned against a version of materialism that forgets that “circumstances are changed by men”

and that the educator must also be educated. The warning is profound because it prevents the analyst from silently granting herself the agency she denies to the people being analyzed.

The more realistic baseline is that almost everyone is continuously doing something about the world, even when an observer considers the chosen action inadequate or ideologically mistaken. People switch jobs, migrate, save, borrow, learn, bargain, care for relatives, start firms, evade rules, comply strategically, join unions, vote, sue, invent, teach, pray, protest, marry, leave, build informal networks, or simply rearrange daily routines. These are not all equally effective, and some are destructive, but they are forms of active adaptation.

This matters because the baseline of consciousness is itself constantly changing through ordinary social transmission. New words make distinctions easier to perceive. New tools reveal previously invisible possibilities. New precedents alter expectations. A legal victory can become vocabulary; vocabulary can become a norm; a norm can become an institution; an institution can become the unremarkable starting point of a child born two generations later. Historical agency is therefore distributed far more widely than theories of passive masses tend to imply.

6. Timescale: Suffering, Patience, and Compound Progress

Many revolutionary theories are psychologically compelling because they begin from suffering that is immediate, severe, and morally intolerable. Under those conditions, gradualism can sound like an insult. If a person is crushed by a system today, being told that institutions may improve over several generations is not much comfort. Any constructive theory has to acknowledge this without romanticizing delay.

Yet timescale still matters. Human progress is cumulative in a way that a snapshot can conceal. Industrial safety rules, labor standards, civil rights, women's rights, minority protections, public health systems, due-process norms, educational access, and technological capabilities did not arrive as a single coherent design. They emerged through a mixture of protest, litigation, bargaining, invention, institution-building, moral persuasion, economic change, political conflict, and ordinary adaptation. Each success created language, precedent, infrastructure, and expectations that made later successes cheaper.

The important distinction is between urgency and forced compression. Urgency says a problem deserves attention now. Forced compression says the entire system must be made to conform to a theoretically preferred end-state on an imposed schedule. Complex adaptive systems resist that kind of treatment. The faster and more centralized the intervention, the larger the epistemic burden placed on the designers and the larger the blast radius when they are wrong.

Compound Progress

A durable reform does more than solve one problem. It creates reusable knowledge, precedent, trust, tools, and institutional capacity. Those assets reduce the cost of solving the next problem. Progress compounds when solutions become infrastructure.

7. Conflict as Diagnosis, Not Ontology

The deepest disagreement with a conflict-centered reading of dialectics is not moral squeamishness about struggle. Conflict is real. Domination is real. Class interests can collide. Institutions can become predatory. People sometimes have to resist, litigate, strike, defend themselves, or refuse cooperation. The narrower claim is that conflict is better understood as a high-cost state that sometimes reveals unresolved incompatibilities than as the fundamental engine of human flourishing.

A conflict ontology changes what the observer notices. If the primary categories are oppressor and oppressed, bourgeois and proletarian, dominant and subordinate, then social reality is organized around antagonism before any particular problem is investigated. This can be diagnostically illuminating where antagonism is genuinely causal. But it can also become self-sealing: cooperation is reinterpreted as concealed domination, reform as co-optation, compromise as weakness, and any persistence of disagreement as proof that the struggle remains fundamental.

A constructive ontology starts elsewhere. It asks: what are people trying to accomplish, what prevents mutually tolerable outcomes, where is the information missing, which incentives are misaligned, what capacity is scarce, and what institutional rule creates unnecessary friction? Sometimes the answer really is coercive domination. Often the upstream cause is less dramatic: a broken feedback loop, a coordination problem, a badly designed interface, a missing market, an information asymmetry, an obsolete law, a shortage of capacity, or a status mechanism that rewards the wrong behavior.

8. Transcending the Enemy: Non-Dualism, Dharma, and Restraint

A construction-centered philosophy gains an ethical orientation from traditions that refuse to make the enemy metaphysically fundamental. In Buddhist and non-dual thought, the division between self and other is treated with suspicion because attachment to rigid identity generates grasping, aversion, and recurring suffering. In the Indian epic and philosophical traditions, dharma, non-attachment, non-agitation, and ahimsa do not amount to passivity; they are disciplines intended to make action less captive to ego, hatred, panic, and revenge.

The strategic insight is similar to the classical preference in Sun Tzu for achieving objectives without battle when possible. Violence can sometimes stop an immediate violence, but it is an extraordinarily expensive tool. It destroys information, capital, relationships, infrastructure, trust, and human beings. Anyone who has to live in the aftermath pays costs that were invisible in the rhetoric preceding the fight.

This is why accepting an aggressor's grammar can be dangerous. If the aggressor says the world is fundamentally a contest for domination and the response is merely to reverse who dominates whom, the underlying paradigm survives. The sides of the horseshoe change; the structure of the game does not. Transcendence means refusing to let the opponent dictate the

ontology. The objective is not to become better at righteous conflict. It is to make the conditions that repeatedly generate destructive conflict less necessary and less rewarding.

This is not naive pacifism. Restraint has meaning precisely because force remains possible. The warrior traditions invoked here are useful symbolically because they understand the cost of action. The strongest preference for peace is often found not in ignorance of violence but in knowledge of its consequences. The relevant discipline is therefore neither submission nor aggression, but controlled capacity: the ability to act decisively without becoming psychologically dependent on the conflict itself.

9. The Problem with Forced Timelines

If history is framed as a struggle whose resolution is both morally urgent and structurally inevitable, coercion becomes dangerously easy to rationalize. Resistance can be interpreted not as information about a flawed design but as evidence of false consciousness, class interest, sabotage, or reaction. The more certain the theory is about the destination, the more tempting it becomes to treat the people who do not cooperate as defects in the implementation.

Engineering offers a different attitude toward resistance: resistance is data. When a system requires enormous monitoring, censorship, punishment, or administrative effort merely to sustain ordinary compliance, the maintenance cost is telling us something about the design. It may still be necessary to enforce some rules, but enforcement should not be confused with proof that the underlying model fits human use.

Large-scale social interventions also create nonlinear externalities. Supply chains, family structures, informal trust networks, credit, local knowledge, political legitimacy, and tacit professional competence interact in ways that no central diagram fully captures. A force applied to one node propagates across many others. This “blast radius” is not an argument for never acting; it is an argument for humility, reversibility where possible, local experimentation, feedback, and preference for solutions that attract participation rather than compel it.

10. Construction as the Primary Historical Technology

If conflict is demoted from ontology to diagnostic signal, construction moves to the center. Human beings advance by building artifacts, institutions, habits, and shared understandings that let more people do more things with less effort and less fear. A successful institution is social infrastructure in the same sense that a bridge is physical infrastructure: it makes a previously expensive transition cheap and repeatable.

This perspective changes the question asked after diagnosis. The destructive question is, “What must be abolished?” The constructive question is, “What function does the existing system currently perform, however badly, and what superior mechanism can perform that function with lower friction?” This is harder because demolition is visually obvious while replacement design requires detailed knowledge. But it is also safer. If an institution persists, it usually

coordinates something, even if it does so unfairly or inefficiently. Destroying the institution without replacing the function transfers its costs onto the people least able to absorb them.

The preferred strategy is therefore obsolescence through superior design. Build the alternative, test it, make it easier to use, make it cheaper, make it more humane, and make migration possible. If the new arrangement truly serves human purposes better, adoption itself becomes part of the proof.

BETTER DESIGN -> LOWER FRICTION -> VOLUNTARY ADOPTION -> SCALE -> OBSOLESCENCE OF WORSE SYSTEMS

11. Two Pillars of Post-Scarcity Infrastructure

The constructive destination can be summarized as post-scarcity, but scarcity must be understood in two linked senses. A society can become materially rich while remaining psychologically organized around fear, status competition, resentment, and zero-sum identity. It can also cultivate inner freedom while leaving people crushed by preventable material deprivation. A durable high-flourishing civilization therefore requires two forms of infrastructure that continuously reinforce one another.

11.1 Material Post-Scarcity

Material post-scarcity does not mean infinite resources. It means pushing the marginal cost, uncertainty, and fragility of basic human capability low enough that survival no longer consumes most human attention. The work is concrete: abundant energy, better storage, housing supply, transport, water, food systems, preventative health, automation, resilient supply chains, high-throughput public infrastructure, and institutions that reduce transaction costs.

The standard of success is not ideological purity but capacity. Does the system give more people reliable access to the things required to live and build? Does it reduce the amount of life spent securing necessities? Does it make shocks less catastrophic? Does it expand the set of projects an ordinary person can attempt?

11.2 Psychological Post-Scarcity

Psychological post-scarcity is the internal analogue: a condition in which people are less governed by fear of insufficiency, humiliation, comparison, ideological enemies, or the belief that agency belongs somewhere else. It is supported by education that develops judgment rather than compliance, communities that generate trust, cultures that honor competence and care, and mental disciplines that make it possible to experience difficulty without immediately converting it into identity or hatred.

This pillar is not an invitation to ignore structural injustice by “thinking positively.” Quite the opposite: agency improves diagnosis because it turns attention toward solvable causes. A psychologically abundant person can look directly at a bad system without needing either to

deny it or to become possessed by it. The question becomes, “What exactly is broken, what is upstream of it, and what can be built?”

Material Post-Scarcity	Psychological Post-Scarcity
Abundant, reliable energy and storage	Internal locus of agency without denial of constraints
Housing, transport, water, food, health capacity	Emotional stability and freedom from zero-sum identity
Automation and tools that lower survival labor	Education for judgment, curiosity, and practical competence
Low-friction markets and public institutions	High-trust communities and cooperative norms
Resilience that reduces the cost of shocks	Ability to face conflict without becoming organized around conflict

The relationship is reciprocal. Material abundance gives people time, safety, and cognitive bandwidth for psychological development. Psychological abundance produces better designers, parents, citizens, entrepreneurs, teachers, and leaders, who in turn build better material systems. The loop is virtuous when both sides are treated as infrastructure rather than as afterthoughts.

12. Marxism as an Exceptional Diagnostic Tool

None of this requires declaring Marxism “bad.” A tool can be excellent and still be misused outside its design envelope. Marxist analysis is particularly strong at locating power asymmetries, showing how material incentives hide beneath moral language, explaining why institutions reproduce themselves, analyzing alienation, and identifying where the gains and burdens of an economic arrangement fall unevenly. Those are diagnostic achievements worth retaining.

The mistake is to treat diagnosis as cure. An MRI can reveal a tumor but cannot perform surgery. A debugger can identify a failing process but does not automatically tell the engineer what architecture should replace it. A theory organized around contradiction can reveal where a system is tearing itself apart without being the best theory for designing a peaceful, adaptive, high-trust replacement.

The practical synthesis is therefore modular rather than sectarian: use Marxist tools where they diagnose real structural pressure; use psychology to understand motivation; use wisdom traditions to orient action away from hatred and compulsive dualism; use economics to

understand incentives and trade-offs; use law to create durable coordination; use science to discover constraints; and use engineering to build systems that actually work.

A Functional Division of Labor

Diagnosis asks: Where is the friction? Orientation asks: What kind of human world is worth building? Construction asks: What mechanism, institution, or technology can reliably move us there? No single intellectual tradition needs to do all three jobs.

13. Begin Locally: You Can Only Give What You Have

A post-scarcity world begins at an unexpectedly small scale: the operating logic of the person trying to build it. Systems reproduce the habits of their designers. A person governed by fear tends to design control. A person governed by humiliation often designs status into the institution. A person addicted to enemies tends to create processes that require enemies. By contrast, someone who can remain curious under pressure is more likely to treat resistance as information rather than insult.

This is the practical meaning of the claim that one can only give what one has. Psychological post-scarcity cannot be distributed by decree. It has to be instantiated in relationships, organizations, classrooms, products, neighborhoods, and decisions. Likewise, material abundance cannot be wished into existence. It has to be produced through patient accumulation of energy systems, tools, knowledge, institutions, and productive capacity.

The two levels meet in everyday practice. Be friendly to the neighbor because trust is infrastructure. Learn the craft because competence is infrastructure. Fix the bottleneck because throughput is infrastructure. Teach the child how to think because judgment is infrastructure. Build the better battery, the better city, the better school, the better scheduling system, the better legal process. The scale varies; the logic is the same.

14. Conclusion: A Better World Must Be Built

Dialectical materialism begins from a truth that should not be discarded: human beings inherit a world they did not choose, and the arrangement of material life profoundly affects what they can see and do. But inherited conditions are not only cages. They are also materials. They are the current state of the sandbox in which human beings continuously act, improvise, cooperate, resist, and build.

The constructive thesis is therefore an inversion of emphasis. Human purposes encounter material conditions as friction. Friction generates information. Agency converts information into experiments. Successful experiments become knowledge and infrastructure. Infrastructure raises the baseline. The higher baseline enables new forms of agency. Over enough iterations, this is what progress looks like: not a final victory of one class over another, but an expanding

capacity for people to live, choose, create, care, and solve problems without wasting their finite lives on unnecessary conflict.

Conflict still belongs in the model, but as a warning light rather than the engine. Sometimes it cannot be avoided. Sometimes resistance is a duty. But a philosophy that needs an enemy in order to move cannot fully describe a world that has learned how not to manufacture enemies. The desired end-state is not better conflict on behalf of better causes. It is the gradual obsolescence of conditions that make destructive conflict rational in the first place.

That future is neither automatic nor utopian. It is an engineering program. Diagnose what fails. Trace symptoms upstream. Preserve whatever function still matters. Build a lower-friction alternative. Test it against human use. Let good solutions compound. Material post-scarcity and psychological post-scarcity then become mutually reinforcing projects rather than slogans. A better world is possible, but only in the literal sense: it has to be constructed.

Notes on Scope and Interpretation

This essay deliberately distinguishes Marx's own writings from later deterministic or orthodox formulations of dialectical materialism. Marx's emphasis on praxis, his insistence that people make history under inherited circumstances, and his critique of passive materialism complicate any simple claim that Marxism denies agency. The argument here is therefore directed primarily at explanatory priority and at conflict-centered political interpretations: material conditions are treated as constraints, inputs, and inherited state; purposive human action is treated as the recurring mechanism by which those conditions are altered.

The paper also uses "post-scarcity" as an asymptotic engineering objective rather than a claim that all scarcity can literally disappear. The operative goal is to reduce the cost, fragility, and psychological dominance of scarcity across basic human capabilities while expanding agency and resilience.

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